CEDAR RIDGE COLLEGE

President's Report

November 2026

to the Board of Trustees

01_allied_health_groundbreaking_01.jpg

Alt text: Dr. Helen Marsh, Board President Ruth Abernathy and four guests in hard hats turn the first shovels of soil at the Allied Health Center site.

FACILITIES

Ground Broken on the Allied Health Center

Cedar Ridge College broke ground on October 22 on the Allied Health Center, a two-story, 38,000-square-foot building that will house the nursing, radiologic technology and medical assisting programs under one roof. The $16.4 million project is funded through the facilities bond approved by voters in 2024 and a state capital outlay grant. President Dr. Helen Marsh was joined by Board President Ruth Abernathy, Trustee Samuel Okonkwo and more than 120 students, faculty and community partners.

Nursing student Marisol Ortega spoke about completing clinical training in rooms built for other purposes and what dedicated simulation labs will mean for the students who follow her. The building is scheduled to open for the fall 2028 semester and will allow the nursing program to grow its entering class from 40 to 64 students each year.

UPCOMING EVENTS

December 4
Winter Choral Concert
Performing Arts Hall

December 11
Fall Nursing Pinning Ceremony
Main Gymnasium

December 12
Holiday Open House
Campus Center

02_qureshi_portrait.jpg

Alt text: Portrait of Dr. Samira Qureshi, Dean of Workforce and Career Programs.

LEADERSHIP

Dr. Samira Qureshi Named Dean of Workforce and Career Programs

Dr. Samira Qureshi has been named Dean of Workforce and Career Programs, effective November 3. Dr. Qureshi comes to Cedar Ridge College from Linden Valley Community College, where she directed apprenticeship partnerships for seven years and built a welding and industrial maintenance pathway with three regional employers.

At Cedar Ridge she will oversee the College's career technical programs, its noncredit workforce certificates and its employer advisory committees. She holds a doctorate in educational leadership and began her career as a high school agriculture teacher. Dr. Marsh introduced her at the October 28 all-staff meeting, noting that the College's new apprenticeship agreements with regional employers will be among her first priorities.

CEREMONY

Veterans Resource Center Honors Student Veterans

The Cedar Ridge College Veterans Resource Center hosted its annual Veterans Day recognition on November 10, honoring the 212 student veterans and military-connected students enrolled this fall. Trustee Teresa Valdivia, a Navy veteran, presented challenge coins to the eleven student veterans who will complete degrees or certificates in December.

Army veteran and nursing student Elena Brandt spoke about the center's peer mentoring program, which pairs new student veterans with classmates who have already made the transition from service to campus. The event closed with the unveiling of a wall of service in the center's lounge, where student veterans can add a photo and their branch of service. The center has served more than 400 students since it opened in 2021.

03_veterans_ceremony_02.jpg

Alt text: Army veteran and nursing student Elena Brandt speaks at a podium in the Veterans Resource Center.



HERITAGE

Día de los Muertos Ofrenda Draws Community to Campus

More than 900 visitors came to campus from October 30 to November 2 for the College's fifth annual Día de los Muertos ofrenda exhibit in the Library Gallery. Students in the Chicano studies, art and ceramics programs built eleven altars honoring family members, community figures and cultural icons, each with a written explanation in English and Spanish.

The exhibit opened with a performance by the College's ballet folklórico student group and a community reception hosted by the Latinx Student Alliance. Local elementary schools brought 14 classes on guided tours led by student volunteers. Trustee Carolyn Ishida attended the opening and joined students in placing marigolds at the community altar.

ATHLETICS

Women's Cross Country Wins Conference Title

The Cedar Ridge College women's cross country team won the Sierra Foothill Conference championship on October 31 at Riverbend Park, the program's first conference title since 2017. The Cougars placed five runners in the top 15, led by sophomore Kayla Nguyen, who won the individual title in 18 minutes, 42 seconds on the 5K course. Head coach Darnell Price was named Conference Coach of the Year.

The team now advances to the regional championship on November 15, where the top four teams qualify for the state meet. Seven of the team's twelve runners are first-generation college students, and the team carries a combined grade point average of 3.31.

